



Fungi and related members of their kingdom are magical organisms—they seem to spring from nowhere overnight. This happens because their microscopic spores are all around us. Mushrooms are actually more likely to appear after rain, which provides good conditions for spores to germinate. The best place to find them is among fallen leaves in temperate woodland.



BRACKET FUNGUS



JACK O'LANTERN



PARASOL



MOREL

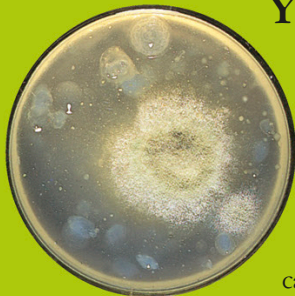
Molds

Molds are microscopic fungi. Their spores are everywhere and germinate very quickly, sending out a mesh of white hyphae through a new food source. When they are ready to reproduce they make colored spores that may be pink, blue, gray, black, or green and appear powdery.



Yeasts

Yeasts are single-celled fungi that live in colonies and absorb nutrients through their cell wall. Most live in liquid environments that are naturally rich in sugar, such as the nectar of flowers. Some yeasts, when fermented, convert carbohydrates to carbon dioxide (used in baking) and alcohol (used in beer brewing).



Lichens

Lichens are really two organisms that live together—a fungus and an alga. The alga lives inside the fungus's tissues, which protect it from the outside world and provides

it with water and nutrients. In return, the alga makes starch by photosynthesis and some of it is used by the fungus. This relationship allows the lichen to survive in tough places, such as on bare desert rocks. Unlike other fungi, lichens grow very slowly—some are hundreds of years old.

The biggest living thing is a fungus. It extends more than 3.8 sq. miles (10 sq. km) under a forest in Oregon and is thought to be 8,500 years old.



growing in the cracks but they are perfectly *edible*.